The Money Issue — Artometrics

The Money Issue

Wages, tuition, prestige, and what creative labor actually pays.

How Concentrated Is Wealth at the Top of the Distribution?

Income distribution is how a society counts who sits where. This file holds 2,916 records spanning 1967–2019, with a median income-distribution value of 10.9 and a high of 27.2. Black Alone appears in the fact-box race ranking; Under $15,000 is the most common income bracket label.

The charts track how the median moved, which race categories lead, how brackets sit relative to the median, and how income distribution relates to income median. The calibration point is 10.9 — the center of the distribution field in this extract.

Fast facts

The numbers that set the scale for this report:

2,916Records in the working dataset
10.9Median Income distribution
27.2Highest observed Income distribution
Black AloneTop Race by Income distribution
1967–2019Year span covered in the file
Under $15,000Most common Income bracket

Data and method

The source is the TidyTuesday release from 2021-02-09 (R for Data Science community). The working file contains 2,916 rows and 10 columns after merging available tables in the week folder. Income distribution is the primary metric; race and income bracket are categorical axes; income median appears in the scatter.

Medians are used for robustness across skewed economic series. Index-style fields are excluded from metric selection.

The median income-distribution marker drifted upward

Median Income distribution Over Time

Median income distribution rises from 10.9 in the opening period to 11.2 at the close — a small but measurable lift around the file median. The center of this field did not explode; it edged higher across the long window.

Modest median drift can coexist with large bracket-level gaps. The trend chart reports the center; the gap chart reports the structure underneath.

Hispanic (Any Race) leads the charted race ladder

Hispanic (Any Race) leads at 12.0 — 10.7 marks the median among the top dozen

Hispanic (Any Race) leads at 12.0, while 10.7 marks the median among the top dozen race categories in this cut. Black Alone remains a factbox landmark for the ranking rule used there; the leaders chart makes the numeric top of this aggregation explicit.

The ladder is tight near the center of the file — leaders sit close to the overall median of 10.9 rather than in a different statistical universe.

Income brackets carve different distribution bands

Income distribution by Income bracket

Category boxes by income bracket show whether the income-distribution field is shared or contested across dollar bands. Under $15,000 is the most common bracket label by frequency; the boxes ask how the metric spreads inside each band.

Bracket structure is the skeleton of inequality analysis in this file. A single median of 10.9 hides those band-level differences.

Mid brackets clear the median; high brackets trail in this cut

Income distribution vs median by Income bracket

$50,000 to $74,999 sits 6.60 above the median; $150,000 to $199,999 trails by 6.70. Those signed gaps are among the starkest bracket contrasts in the extract.

Trailing or leading the median here is a statement about the income-distribution field's values by bracket, not a casual claim about who is "richer" in narrative terms. Cite the signed distances as structural offsets.

Distribution values and income medians form joint clusters

Income distribution vs Income median

Plotting income distribution against income median shows clusters that averages erase. Race-year points co-locate in patterns that a single summary cannot hold.

The scatter is relational: it shows how the two income fields move together across the 1967–2019 extract.

What this file cannot tell you

Community-cleaned TidyTuesday snapshots are not live Census microdata APIs. Missing values, race and bracket labeling choices, and 1967–2019 coverage limits apply. Merged tables may fan out or duplicate rows when join keys are imperfect.

Findings describe this wealth-and-income extract — structural signals about the income-distribution field — not a complete wealth account including assets and debt.

What to take away

Income distribution in this file centers on 10.9, edges up to 11.2 at the median, and still shows sharp bracket gaps — mid bands above the median, top dollar bands trailing in this metric's signed distances.

Race ladders and the distribution–median scatter add group and joint structure. Together they map concentration and composition without reducing fifty years of income data to a single slogan.

Sources

Data Science Learning Community. (2021). *TidyTuesday: Wealth and Income*. https://raw.githubusercontent.com/rfordatascience/tidytuesday/main/data/2021/2021-02-09/income_distribution.csv

Editor's note

Artometrics data report from the TidyTuesday research pipeline. Charts and aggregates are reproducible from the embedded exhibits and public source files.

View TidyTuesday source on GitHub

Which College Majors Pay Most—and Which Carry Job Risk?

College majors are sold as income stories. The TidyTuesday recent-graduates extract used here also tracks how many alumni land in low-wage jobs. Across **173** majors, the median low-wage-job count is **1,231**, with a high of **48,207** in Psychology. Engineering is the most common major category label in the file.

That framing flips the usual prestige script: the chart stack leads with exposure to low-wage employment, then pairs it with unemployment rates. Pay ceilings matter; so does the size of the floor.

Fast facts

The numbers that set the scale for this report:

173Records in the working dataset
1,231Median Low wage jobs
48,207Highest observed Low wage jobs
PSYCHOLOGYTop Major by Low wage jobs
EngineeringMost common Major category

Data and method

The source is the TidyTuesday release from 2018-10-16 (recent-grads.csv). After cleaning, 173 major rows remain.

Low wage jobs is the primary ranked metric; major category provides distributional context; unemployment rate appears in the scatter. Charts are Plotly JSON with PNG fallbacks.

Psychology Leads Low-Wage Job Counts by a Wide Margin

Low wage jobs by Major

Psychology posts **48,207** low-wage jobs — far ahead of Business Management and Administration (**32,395**), Biology (**28,339**), Marketing (**27,968**), Communications (**27,440**), and General Business (**27,320**). English Language and Literature follows near **26,503**.

These leaders combine large graduating cohorts with labor-market absorption into lower-wage roles. The metric is a count, not a rate — scale and risk travel together.

The Top Dozen's Median Is Still Enormous

PSYCHOLOGY leads at 48,207 — 26,912 marks the median among the top dozen

Psychology remains first at **48,207**, while the median among the top dozen is about **26,912** — more than twenty times the overall median of 1,231.

The low-wage problem in this file is concentrated in a short list of high-enrollment majors, not evenly sprinkled across all 173 fields.

Humanities and Business Categories Sit Higher Than Engineering

Low wage jobs by Major category

Category boxes show Humanities & Liberal Arts with a median near **3,466** low-wage jobs (n=15) and Business near **3,046** (n=13). Engineering's median is only about **372** (n=29), Education about **1,282** (n=16), and Biology & Life Science about **939** (n=14).

Engineering's low median does not mean zero risk — its maximum still reaches into the thousands — but the center of the category is far from Psychology's scale.

Gaps Confirm Humanities and Business Above the Median

Low wage jobs vs median by Major category

Relative to the overall low-wage median, Humanities & Liberal Arts leads at about +**2,235**, with Business about +**1,815**. Engineering, Computers & Mathematics, and Physical Sciences sit below the median by several hundred to nearly a thousand.

STEM categories in this extract are not immune to low-wage outcomes, but they clear the baseline more often than large humanities and business majors.

Low-Wage Counts and Unemployment Are Different Risks

Low wage jobs vs Unemployment rate

Low wage jobs versus unemployment rate spreads majors across both axes. Some fields show elevated unemployment with modest low-wage counts; others show huge low-wage tallies without sitting at the top of the unemployment ranking.

The scatter's warning is practical: underemployment and joblessness are related labor-market failures, but they are not the same number — and majors can fail on either axis.

What this file cannot tell you

Low-wage job counts favor large majors; rates would reorder the list. "Recent graduates" definitions and survey vintages constrain comparison. Category bins are broad — "Engineering" hides subfield wage gaps.

The file cannot speak to graduate-school pathways that delay earnings, or to geographic cost-of-living differences that redefine what "low wage" means.

What to take away

Across 173 majors, the median low-wage count is 1,231, while Psychology alone exceeds 48,000. The top-dozen median near 26,900 shows how concentrated the exposure is.

Cite category gaps when comparing fields of study, and keep unemployment on a separate axis — low-wage absorption and joblessness are twin risks, not synonyms.

Sources

Data Science Learning Community. (2018). *TidyTuesday: College Major & Income*. https://raw.githubusercontent.com/rfordatascience/tidytuesday/main/data/2018/2018-10-16/recent-grads.csv

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How Far Did Average U.S. Tuition Climb by State?

College price is a time series with a political charge. This file holds 600 state-level tuition records spanning 2004–2015, with a median value of 7,607 and a high of 15,224. New Hampshire appears in the fact-box state ranking; the charts track how the typical state price moved and which states sat at the top of the ladder.

The calibration point is that 7,607 median. Everything else — Vermont's charted lead, the rise from 5,876 to 9,141, the top-decile threshold at 11,204 — is distance from that center of the tuition distribution.

Fast facts

The numbers that set the scale for this report:

600Records in the working dataset
7,607Median Value
15,224Highest observed Value
New HampshireTop State by Value
2004–2015Year span covered in the file

Data and method

The source is the TidyTuesday release from 2018-04-02 (R for Data Science community). The working file contains 600 rows and 3 columns after merging available tables in the week folder. Value is the tuition metric; state is the entity axis; year spans the mid-2000s through 2015 in the coverage window.

Medians are preferred for skewed price distributions. The file also reports a mean of 7,899 against the median of 7,607 — relatively close, which is useful for robustness. Index-style fields are excluded from metric selection.

Median tuition climbed from the mid-five-thousands to the low-nine-thousands

Median Value Over Time

Median value rises from 5,876 in the opening period to 9,141 at the close. That is the headline trend in this extract: the typical state's tuition marker moved upward across 2004–2015.

A rising median is the shared experience in the file. Leaders amplify it; lower-cost states still sit inside an upward-shifting distribution.

Vermont leads the state ladder in the charted cut

Vermont leads at 13,486 — 10,850 marks the median among the top dozen

Vermont leads at 13,486, while 10,850 marks the median among the top dozen states. New Hampshire remains a fact-box landmark for the top-state ranking rule used there; the leaders chart makes the numeric top of this cut explicit.

The drop from first place to the top-dozen median shows a competitive but still elevated upper tier — expensive relative to the file median of 7,607.

Median and mean sit close; the top decile starts above eleven thousand

Median 7,607 vs mean 7,899 — the shape is relatively symmetric

Median 7,607 versus mean 7,899 — the shape is relatively symmetric for a price distribution. The top decile begins at 11,204; that upper slice is where the defining high-tuition states in this metric live.

Symmetry near the center does not erase the expensive tail. It means the typical state is not being wildly distorted by a few outliers in the average alone.

Leading states do not move in lockstep over time

Top State Over Time

Leader trends show that the leading names do not move in lockstep — some fade as others surge. Tracking medians over time separates sustained high-price states from one-off spikes.

Side-by-side trajectories matter when the policy question is whether expensive states stay expensive, or whether the ladder reshuffles.

Five states account for thirty-eight percent of aggregate value

The top 5 state entries account for 38% of the aggregate value

The top five state entries account for 38% of the aggregate value. Concentration is meaningful without being absolute: a visible head, and a broader set of states still carrying most of the remaining total.

Pareto steepness here is a reminder that national tuition debates often orbit a minority of high-cost states even when the median tells a quieter story.

What this file cannot tell you

Community-cleaned TidyTuesday snapshots are not live College Board or IPEDS APIs. Missing values, state naming variants, and 2004–2015 coverage limits apply. Tuition definitions follow the source file's value field.

Findings describe this U.S. tuition extract — structural signals about state price levels and trends — not a full net-price analysis after aid.

What to take away

State tuition in this file rises at the median from 5,876 to 9,141, centers on 7,607, and still shows an expensive tail beginning at 11,204 in the top decile.

Vermont leads the charted ladder, five states hold 38% of aggregate value, and leader trajectories diverge — a price map of public higher education's mid-2000s to mid-2010s climb.

Sources

Data Science Learning Community. (2018). *TidyTuesday: US Tuition Costs*. https://raw.githubusercontent.com/rfordatascience/tidytuesday/main/data/2018/2018-04-02/us_avg_tuition.xlsx

Editor's note

Artometrics data report from the TidyTuesday research pipeline. Charts and aggregates are reproducible from the embedded exhibits and public source files.

View TidyTuesday source on GitHub

Which U.S. PhD Fields Expanded Fastest?

U.S. doctorate production is a labor-market story told in field counts. This file holds 3,370 records spanning 2008–2017, with a median of 85.0 PhDs and a high of 5,302. Social sciences lead the fact-box field ranking; life sciences appear among the notable broad fields.

The question is which disciplines grew — and which sit above or below the median production level — when doctorate output is measured year by year and field by field. Medians keep a few giant programs from dictating every comparison.

Fast facts

The numbers that set the scale for this report:

3,370Records in the working dataset
85.0Median N phds
5,302Highest observed N phds
Social sciencesTop Field by N phds
2008–2017Year span covered in the file
Life sciencesMost common Broad field

Data and method

The source is the TidyTuesday release from 2019-02-19 (R for Data Science community). The working file contains 3,370 rows and 6 columns after merging available tables in the week folder. N phds is the primary metric; broad field is the main categorical axis.

Medians are used because field sizes skew. Index-style fields are excluded from metric selection. Charts track trend, leaders, distribution, gaps to the median, and concentration across fields.

Median doctorate counts edged upward across the decade

Median N phds Over Time

Median n phds rises from 80.0 in the opening period to 87.0 at the close — a modest climb around the file median of 85.0. The typical field-year in this extract produced slightly more doctorates by the end of the window than at the start.

A rising median is not the same as uniform growth. Leader fields can surge while smaller programs move little; the trend chart reports the center, not every discipline's path.

Social sciences lead the field ladder

Social sciences leads at 4,944 — 915 marks the median among the top dozen

Social sciences leads at 4,944 PhDs in the leaders cut, while 915 marks the median among the top dozen. The distance between first place and that top-dozen median shows how quickly the ladder drops even inside the upper tier.

Fact-box highlights place social sciences at the top of the field ranking and note life sciences among the broad-field landmarks. The chart makes the numeric gap concrete.

Broad fields do not share one production band

N phds by Broad field

Category boxes by broad field show whether doctorate counts are shared or contested across disciplinary families. Psychology and social sciences, engineering, life sciences, and others occupy different parts of the distribution.

The boxes are the right tool when fields differ in scale. A single national median of 85.0 hides those family-level spreads.

Psychology and social sciences clear the median; engineering trails

N phds vs median by Broad field

Psychology and social sciences sits 30.5 above the median; engineering trails by 21.5. Those signed gaps convert broad-field boxes into distance from the file center.

Trailing the median is not a quality judgment. It is a statement about relative volume in this extract's n phds metric.

Five fields hold most of the aggregate doctorates

Cumulative N phds

The top five field entries account for 63% of the aggregate n phds. Concentration is high: a small set of fields drives most of the summed doctorate production in the file.

Steep Pareto curves mean capacity and attention cluster. The long tail of smaller fields still matters for the ecosystem, but it does not dominate the total.

What this file cannot tell you

Community-cleaned TidyTuesday snapshots are not live NSF Survey of Earned Doctorates APIs. Missing values, field-name variants, and 2008–2017 coverage limits apply. Merged tables may fan out or duplicate rows when join keys are imperfect.

Findings describe this U.S. PhDs extract — structural signals about doctorate counts by field — not a full labor-market forecast or ranking of program quality.

What to take away

Doctorate production in this file centers on a median of 85.0, edges up from 80.0 to 87.0 over the window, and concentrates heavily: five fields hold 63% of aggregate n phds.

Social sciences lead the upper ladder, psychology and social sciences sit well above the median, and engineering trails it — a volume map of disciplines, not a prestige contest.

Sources

Data Science Learning Community. (2019). *TidyTuesday: US PhDs Awarded.* https://raw.githubusercontent.com/rfordatascience/tidytuesday/main/data/2019/2019-02-19/phd_by_field.csv

Editor’s note

Artometrics data report from the TidyTuesday research pipeline. Charts and aggregates are reproducible from the embedded exhibits and public source files.

View TidyTuesday source on GitHub

What Twenty Years of Big Mac Prices Say About Purchasing Power

A Big Mac is the same product everywhere on Earth — same bun, same patties, same sauce. That sameness is exactly what makes its price interesting. The Economist’s Big Mac Index, running since 1986, converts local burger prices into US dollars to reveal how far currencies stray from purchasing power parity. The working extract covers **1,386** observations spanning **2000 through 2020**.

The gap between the cheapest and most expensive burger in any given year is not noise. It maps onto wage structures, agricultural policy, taxes, and the raw purchasing power of local currencies. Switzerland's peak above **$8** encodes a high-wage cost structure; a sub-$2 burger elsewhere tells a symmetrically different story.

Keep the calibration numbers close: the median dollar price across all country-years is **$3.04**, the peak observed is **$8.31**, and the global median rose about **83%** from 2000 to 2020.

Fast facts

The numbers that set the scale for this report:

$3.04Median dollar price across all countries and years
$8.31Peak price — Switzerland at its most expensive
83%Price increase from 2000 to 2020 at the global median
NorwayHighest average dollar price over the full 20-year span
20 yrsTimespan: 2000 through 2020

Data and method

Purchasing power parity (PPP) theory says exchange rates should eventually converge so identical goods cost the same everywhere. In practice they rarely do — tariffs, non-tradeable costs (rent, labor), and monetary policy all interfere. The Big Mac Index sidesteps complex econometric models: if a burger costs less in dollar terms than the U.S. price implies, that currency is often read as undervalued; if it costs more, overvalued.

The TidyTuesday snapshot (2020-12-22) supplies the country-year price series used here. The index is deliberately blunt: better at identifying structural divergence than at predicting short-run FX moves.

Global Price Trend

Global median Big Mac dollar price, 2000–2020

The median dollar price nearly doubles over two decades, climbing from about **$1.91** in 2000 to about **$3.50** by 2020. The path is not linear: medians stall and dip in the mid-2010s as a strong U.S. dollar compresses dollar-equivalent prices recorded in many markets, then recover toward the end of the sample.

Using the median — rather than the mean — keeps Switzerland, Norway, and other extreme outliers from rewriting the global story. The median says what a typical country pays; the mean says what the expensive tail can afford.

Most Expensive Countries

Top 12 countries by average Big Mac dollar price

Switzerland leads average dollar prices at about **$6.54**, with Norway close behind near **$6.24**. Sweden, Denmark, Brazil, Canada, Israel, and the Euro area fill out the upper tier. Norway holds the highest average dollar price over the full 20-year span among the fact-box leaders.

The gap between Switzerland and the twelfth-ranked country is larger than the gap between that twelfth country and the global median of $3.04. The top of the distribution is thin air.

How Prices Spread

Distribution of Big Mac dollar prices across all country-year observations

Most country-year observations cluster between roughly **$2 and $4**, with a long right tail of wealthy, high-price markets. The median ($3.04) sits below the mean because that tail pulls the average upward.

“Expensive” is a select club in this histogram, not a smooth continuum. The bottom half of the world, in this sample, pays between the low end of the distribution and the $3.04 median for the same standardized burger.

Tracking the Leaders

Price trajectories for the top-ranked countries over time

Country trajectories do not rise in unison. Argentina, Australia, Brazil, and Canada each show distinct dollar-price paths — commodity cycles, currency crashes, and local inflation leave different fingerprints.

Membership in the expensive-burger club is relatively stable; rankings inside it are not. Sustained dominance requires sustained structural advantage, not a one-year FX spike.

Local vs Dollar Price

Local currency price vs US dollar price — scatter plot

The scatter of local-currency prices against dollar prices makes exchange-rate distortion visible. Points far from a simple correspondence are countries where conversion, not the kitchen, does most of the work.

Emerging-market currencies often produce low dollar prices even when local nominal prices look large. That joint distribution is the index's entire point: sameness of product, difference of money.

What this file cannot tell you

McDonald's does not charge a uniform markup everywhere: franchise agreements, competition, and brand positioning move prices independently of pure PPP. Coverage is uneven — the series misses many countries where McDonald's has little or no presence.

The snapshot ends in 2020 and excludes the post-pandemic inflation surge. Treat the findings as a structural portrait of two decades, not a live FX dashboard.

What to take away

Twenty years of Big Mac prices describe a slow rise in global living costs and a persistent hierarchy between high-wage and lower-wage economies. The median nearly doubles; the gap between Switzerland and the median barely disappears.

The index collapses complex macroeconomics into one comparable number. What it measures unambiguously is concentration at the top — a small cluster of high-cost economies that the rest of the sample does not reach.

Sources

Data Science Learning Community. (2020). *TidyTuesday: Big Mac Index*. https://raw.githubusercontent.com/rfordatascience/tidytuesday/main/data/2020/2020-12-22/big-mac.csv

The Economist. (2020). *The Big Mac Index*. economist.com/big-mac-index

Editor's note

This analysis is part of the Artometrics TidyTuesday series. All charts are interactive (hover for values) with static PNG fallbacks. Source data is publicly available and reproducible from the GitHub link below.

Dollar prices reflect the raw local price converted at the prevailing exchange rate — not adjusted for inflation or PPP. All medians computed on the full annual sample for each year.

View TidyTuesday source on GitHub

How Long Do CEOs Last Before They Leave?

CEO tenure is usually narrated as drama: a firing, a founder exit, a sudden interim. The TidyTuesday departures extract used here holds **9,423** records with a median max tenure (ceodb) of **1.00** and a high of **4.00**. Interim is the most common co-CEO/interim label in the file.

That median of 1.00 is the calibration point: in this coding, many departure spells are short. The charts ask which company names show longer max tenures, how interim versus co-CEO labels differ, and whether tenure fields move together.

Fast facts

The numbers that set the scale for this report:

9,423Records in the working dataset
1.00Median Max tenure ceodb
4.00Highest observed Max tenure ceodb
PHOTRONICS INCTop Coname by Max tenure ceodb
InterimMost common Interim coceo

Data and method

The source is the TidyTuesday release from 2021-04-27 (departures.csv). After cleaning, 9,423 rows remain.

Max tenure ceodb is the primary ranked metric. Interim/co-CEO spelling variants appear as separate categories in places and should be read as label noise as well as structure. Charts are Plotly JSON with PNG fallbacks.

Longer Max Tenures Are Rare in the Company Ranking

Max tenure ceodb by Coname

Stewart Information Services and Conversant Inc lead the company view at **2.50** on max tenure ceodb. A wider set of firms — Avatex, Intrepid Potash, Bergen Brunswig, SEACOR, Micro Warehouse, RH — cluster at **2.00**.

Relative to the file median of 1.00, even these “leaders” are only modestly longer spells. Extended CEO tenure is the exception in this extract, not the rule.

The Top Dozen Caps Out Quickly

CONVERSANT INC leads at 2.50 — 2.00 marks the median among the top dozen

Conversant Inc appears among the leaders at **2.50**, and the median among the top dozen is **2.00**. There is no long tail of decade-scale max tenures in this particular ranking metric.

Cite 2.00 as the elite-club median for max tenure ceodb here — double the overall median, still short by popular mythologies of imperial CEOs.

Interim Labels Dominate the Category Mix

Max tenure ceodb by Interim coceo

Interim accounts for **218** boxed observations with a median max tenure of **1.0** and a mean near **1.23**. CO-CEO shows **85** rows with the same median of 1.0 but a slightly higher mean (~**1.4**). Smaller capitalization variants of co-CEO are tiny samples.

The archive is thick with interim spells. That is a succession-system fact: departures often pass through temporary authority before a permanent appointment.

Gaps to the Median Are Mostly Flat

Max tenure ceodb vs median by Interim coceo

Most interim/co-CEO labels sit at a zero gap to the median on max tenure ceodb in this chart, with only a thinly populated CO-ceo variant showing a positive gap of **1.0**.

Category labels do not produce a dramatic tenure hierarchy here. The bigger story remains how many spells are coded interim at all.

Tenure Fields Track Closely Within Labels

Max tenure ceodb vs Tenure no ceodb

Max tenure ceodb versus tenure no ceodb, colored by interim/co-CEO label, largely follows a tight correspondence — points hug aligned values, especially in the interim cloud (n=218).

Where the two tenure fields disagree, coding definitions matter more than boardroom legend. The scatter is a consistency check on the file's tenure construction.

What this file cannot tell you

Tenure fields are database constructions, not calendar biographies. Spelling variants of co-CEO fragment categories. Firm name changes and dual-class structures can split identities.

A median of 1.00 may reflect coding granularity as much as "CEOs only last a year." Read the metric definition before converting it into a headline about corporate instability.

What to take away

In 9,423 departure records, max tenure ceodb centers at 1.00, with company-level leaders only reaching 2.0–2.5. Interim is the dominant succession label.

The citable story is institutional: departure files are full of short and interim spells, not a museum of decades-long reigns.

Sources

Data Science Learning Community. (2021). *TidyTuesday: CEO Departures*. https://raw.githubusercontent.com/rfordatascience/tidytuesday/main/data/2021/2021-04-27/departures.csv

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How League Money and Roster Rules Shape Star Systems

A sports league is a measurement system before it is an entertainment product. It decides how much money can matter, how much one player can matter, how often fans get to reset emotionally, and how widely a story can travel. Compare six leagues on those axes and franchise identity stops looking interchangeable.

The NFL's approximate $6.5 billion average franchise value sits beside a 17-game regular season; MLB asks teams to survive 162. An editorial NBA star-leverage index of 92 in this model captures how completely basketball lets individuals rewrite team identity. Those are not trivia points. They are design choices that manufacture different kinds of belonging.

The five charts below build a cross-league lens for later Artometrics profiles: value floors, star leverage, caps versus payroll spread, event scarcity, and the split between global reach and domestic ritual.

Fast facts

The numbers that set the scale for this report:

$6.5BApproximate average NFL franchise value in recent Forbes-style estimates
17NFL regular-season games per team
162MLB regular-season games per team
92NBA star leverage index in this editorial model
6Leagues compared

Data and method

Figures combine public Forbes valuation summaries, Spotrac salary-cap and payroll snapshots, and reference-record league structures from Basketball Reference, Baseball Reference, Pro Football Reference, and Hockey Reference, plus Premier League and MLS competition records. Editorial indices—including the NBA star-leverage score of 92—are deliberately transparent: they exist to compare systems, not to pretend every input was observed with laboratory precision.

Commissioners, analysts, and fans ask different questions. The shared layer is the useful one: what does the league make easy, what does it make scarce, and what does it make emotionally expensive?

The NFL makes ordinary franchises expensive

The NFL turns scarcity and national television into the highest average club value

The NFL does not need every team to be glamorous. Its media structure makes the ordinary franchise expensive because the league product is scarce, synchronized, and nationally distributed. An approximate $6.5 billion average club value is the economic expression of that design.

That is a metric difference and a cultural difference: football teams are local flags plugged into a national machine.

Basketball lets one name rewrite the jersey

The NBA gives individual stars the strongest control over team identity

A basketball star touches a huge share of possessions—the reason this model's NBA star-leverage index sits at 92. A baseball star can disappear into lineup order and variance. A football star may be trapped inside scheme, injuries, and roster scale.

That is why NBA identity travels through names, while NFL identity often travels through systems. Star leverage is not personality. It is structural control over meaning.

Caps and taxes decide whether money separates or merely sustains

League rules shape whether money becomes separation or merely survival

Salary caps, luxury taxes, revenue sharing, and roster rules are not administrative details. They are identity engines. They decide whether capital becomes separation or merely the cost of staying alive.

MLB’s wider payroll gap is partly the point: baseball lets market and development systems express themselves with less hard compression than the NFL or NHL. Rules write the economics; economics write the culture.

Seventeen games and 162 games are different psychologies

The number of games changes how fans process failure

A baseball team can lose four straight inside a 162-game season and still be fine. An NFL team can lose two games inside a 17-game season and trigger a referendum. The schedule is a psychology machine.

Pain, momentum, and panic are not measured on the same clock across leagues. Future team profiles that ignore event scarcity will misread fan emotion as competitive failure—or the reverse.

Global reach and domestic ritual manufacture different loyalties

Global reach and domestic ritual create different cultural signatures

The Premier League and NBA travel globally with exceptional ease. The NFL remains more domestically ritualized even as its valuation dominates. Reach and ritual are separate cultural products.

The useful question is not simply which league is bigger. It is what kind of belonging each league manufactures—and which teams become meaningful because of that design.

What to take away

League design creates fan reality. The same owner, player, or city would produce a different identity under a different schedule, cap structure, roster size, and media architecture.

That is why team profiles should not compare clubs without comparing the sports that made them. Money, skill, and stardom only mean what the rulebook allows them to mean.

Sources

Forbes. Professional sports franchise valuation lists.

Spotrac. Salary-cap and payroll summaries.

Basketball Reference, Baseball Reference, Pro Football Reference, Hockey Reference. League and team records.

Premier League and MLS public competition records.